

NIGHTJARS

All nightjars and their relatives are nocturnal. Most are insect-eaters, snatching their prey on the wing using an exceptionally wide bill gape.

Voracious predators by night, concealed by cryptic plumage during the day, nightjars have similarities to owls, and some ornithologists have thought the two groups to be related. Recent studies, however, link nightjars with swifts and hummingbirds. The connection is supported by features such as the weakness of their feet and the ability of some species to enter a torpid state.

Nightjars belong to the order Caprimulgiformes. Typically, they have a big head and long wings for quick aerial manoeuvres. Their short bill opens enormously wide to catch flying insects. The gape

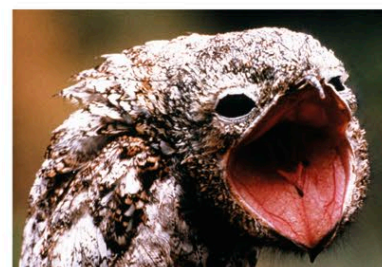
is particularly wide in the aptly named frogmouths from Australasia, which are predators of small vertebrates. Of the group, only the oilbird is vegetarian: a fruit-eater that roosts by day in caves.

All these birds are masters of camouflage. Nightjars blend perfectly with forest litter when on the ground; in trees they perch lengthways on a branch to minimize detection. Frogmouths and potoos freeze when disturbed to mimic tree stumps, closing their eyes to complete the effect.

MINIMAL NESTS

All in this group are minimalist nesters. Nightjars simply lay their eggs in leaf litter on the ground. For oilbirds, a nest is a pile of droppings on a cave ledge, while potoos use nothing more than a depression on a branch.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	CAPRIMULGIFORMES
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	122



A great potoo opens its enormous gape, displaying a key feature of a group of birds that can scoop up flying insects on the wing.



OILBIRD

Steatornis caripensis
F: Steatornithidae

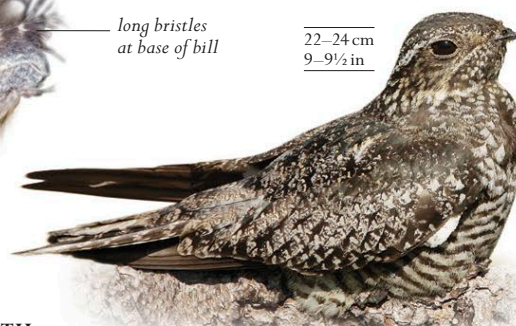
A fruit-eating relative of nightjars, this cave-nesting species from northern S. America is the only nocturnal bird that navigates by echolocation.

41–48 cm
16–19 in

orange-yellow eye

long bristles at base of bill

22–24 cm
9–9½ in



COMMON NIGHTHAWK

Chordeiles minor
F: Caprimulgidae

Nighthawks lack the bill bristles of nightjars, and this absence perhaps helps in their aerial pursuit of insects. This insect-eater migrates between N. and S. America.

20 cm
8 in

OCELLATED POORWILL

Nyctiphrynus ocellatus
F: Caprimulgidae

Poorwills are small American nightjars, so called because of their mournful, monotonous calls. This dark-coloured species occurs in tropical forests.

24–28 cm
9½–11 in



TAWNY FROGMOUTH

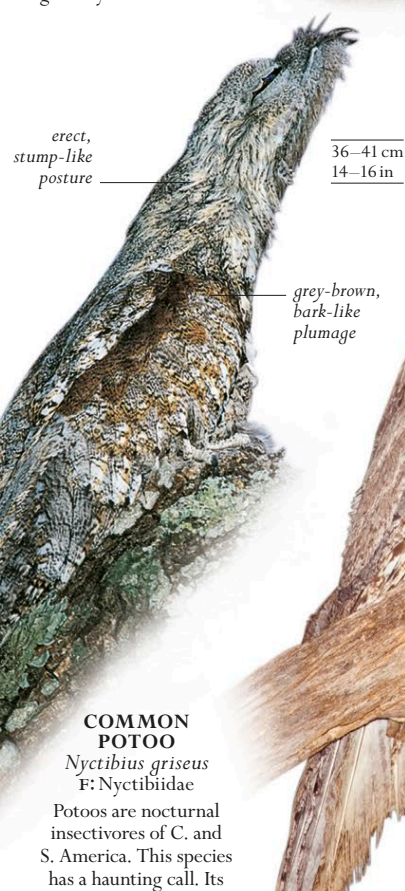
Podargus strigoides
F: Podargidae

This nocturnal Australian bird hunts from perches. Like other frogmouths, it roosts motionless during the day, resembling a broken branch.

32–46 cm
12½–18 in



grey mottled plumage



erect, stump-like posture

36–41 cm
14–16 in

grey-brown, bark-like plumage

COMMON POTOO

Nyctibius griseus
F: Nyctibiidae

Potoos are nocturnal insectivores of C. and S. America. This species has a haunting call. Its plumage provides excellent camouflage against tree bark.

COMMON POORWILL

Phalaenoptilus nuttallii
F: Caprimulgidae

From arid parts of the USA and Mexico, this small nightjar is one of the few birds that enters a hibernation-like torpor in winter.

19–21 cm
7½–8½ in



COMMON PAURAQUE

Nyctidromus albigollis
F: Caprimulgidae

This C. and S. American nighthawk frequents scrubby habitats. It is often seen resting on dirt roads at night.